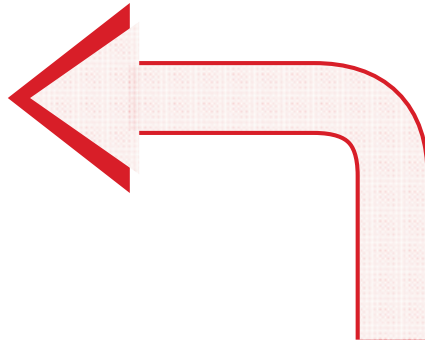


Left Turn

A Quarterly Journal of Critical Voices



Abduction in Caracas

Tariq Ali

Mokhiber on UN Security Council Abomination

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Gaza Tribunal Jury of Conscience

The Jury of Conscience

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Notes from the Editors

***Genocide in Gaza*, by Avi Shlaim**

As Israel's genocidal assault on Gaza with the full backing of the United States devastated Gaza, the urgency of clear, historically grounded analysis has never been greater. *Genocide in Gaza* intervenes at a moment when mass movements across the globe — from campus encampments to port blockades and street mobilizations — are refusing the narratives that have long insulated Israeli state violence from accountability. Avi Shlaim's work provides essential intellectual ammunition for this struggle.

Against decades of liberal obfuscation and media distortion, Shlaim situates Gaza not as an exceptional crisis but as the logical outcome of Zionist settler colonialism and its doctrine of permanent war against an Indigenous population. At a time when organizers are demanding an end to U.S. military aid, sanctions on Israel, and justice for Palestine, *Genocide in Gaza* connects scholarship to struggle. It speaks directly to activists, students, and readers seeking to understand how imperial power, racialized violence, and colonial logics converge in Gaza — and why solidarity with Palestine is inseparable from broader fights against empire, racism, and global apartheid.

Community Organizer & Self-Identified Socialist Wins Seattle Mayoral Race

Katie Wilson has been elected mayor of Seattle, defeating incumbent Bruce Harrell. Wilson's campaign focused on affordable housing, rental protection, transportation, a higher minimum wage, cost of living and fast-tracking shelter space. Harrell, an establishment Democrat, was perceived as the candidate of local tech executives. Wilson said, "I want a city where your health and longevity, and your children's future, don't depend on your zip code or your race."

Only a few hours before giving her acceptance speech, Wilson was chanting with attendees at a Starbucks strike rally where she also gave a

short speech. Wilson will be the first-ever socialist-identified Mayor of Seattle.

Abduction in Caracas

Tariq Ali

Two decades before US forces kidnapped Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro this weekend, Hugo Chávez had already predicted the approach:

Years ago, someone told me: ‘They’re going to end up accusing you of being a drug trafficker — you personally — you, Chávez. Not just that the government supports it, or permits it — no, no, no. They’re going to try to apply the Noriega formula to you.’ They’re looking for a way to associate Chávez directly with drug trafficking. And then, anything goes against a ‘drug trafficker president’, right?

On the morning of 3 January, Trump tweeted a Happy New Year message. The US had carried out ‘a large scale strike on Venezuela and its leader’. President Maduro and his wife Cilia had been ‘captured and flown out of the Country’. Trump said more details would follow in a few hours’ time. The details, however, were confused.

Later that day, an old friend from Caracas rang to say that secret negotiations had been taking place for some time between the regime and the Americans. The Americans wanted Maduro’s head, which he refused to supply — according to the *New York Times*, he was offered transport to a well-cushioned retirement in Turkey, which he scorned, to his great credit. And though repeatedly offering to negotiate with Washington on questions of oil and US drug imports, he was also rallying Venezuelans against Trump’s military build-up in the Caribbean.

The Trump Administration evidently preferred negotiating with Delcy Rodríguez, the vice-president, and others in Venezuela, where the two key ministers are Diosdado Cabello at the Interior

Ministry and Vladimir Padrino at Defence. Both have support in the Army, some 100,000 strong, and Cabello also commands the popular militia forces, which are said to be larger still. As Trump reinforced his threatening armada over the past few months, the Maduro government responded by arming sections of the population.

The question of who now governs Venezuela has therefore become crucial. The first answer came from Trump: ‘We are going to run the country until such time as we can do a safe, proper and judicious transition.’ But the Trump Administration is caught in a cleft stick. Trump’s MAGA base is not in favour of sending American troops to be killed in foreign countries — this was a central part of the campaign they waged against the Democrats and the old GOP establishment over Afghanistan and Iraq. They do not want US troops on the ground in Venezuela. At the same time, the hard-right Latino *émigré* ultras represented by Rubio are unhappy that Bolivarians are still in office in Caracas.

There was talk at one point that Marco Rubio might be appointed de facto governor or consul, to give orders to the Venezuelan government. Meanwhile, messages from Caracas have been mixed. The day after the capture of Maduro, Cabello declared:

This is an attack against Venezuela. We are in position. We call on our people to remain calm and to trust the leadership. Do not allow anyone to become discouraged or make the situation easier for the aggressive enemy.

Rodríguez, confirmed by the Venezuelan Supreme Court as interim president for the next three months, went on state TV to call for Maduro’s release. Trump attacked her in an interview with *The Atlantic* for not being sufficiently pliant, saying she made promises that must now be kept, and threatening: ‘If she doesn’t do what’s right, she is going to pay a very big price, probably bigger than Maduro.’ He went on: ‘Regime change, anything you want to call it, is better than what you have right now. Can’t get any worse.’

The Trump Administration seems incapable of grasping that — whatever people think of Maduro — very few Venezuelans welcome an invasion of their country by the United States. This is a tradition that goes back to Simón Bolívar, who warned specifically that Latin America must beware the new empire to the north and resist exchanging Spanish for American domination. Since Sunday, there have been demonstrations in many different parts of the country demanding Maduro's release, including a huge one in Caracas itself. The dismay goes well beyond the support base of the regime. A leading anti-Maduro Catholic leader, interviewed on BBC Radio 4 on 5 January, was told, 'You must be very happy now'. He replied: 'No, we are not happy. We don't like our country being occupied, and the majority of Venezuelans don't want it to be occupied.'



As Chávez warned, Trump and Rubio have been trying to fit up Maduro on 'narco-terrorism' charges, the latest iteration of those invisible weapons of mass destruction in Iraq. 'Maduro is NOT the president of Venezuela', Rubio tweeted last summer, 'and his regime is NOT the legitimate government. Maduro is the head of the Cartel de Los Soles, a narco-terror organization which has taken possession of a country. And he is under indictment for pushing drugs into the United States.'

As is well known, Rubio himself comes from a distinguished cocaine family, heavily implicated in the drug trade throughout South America. His relatives have been involved in smuggling cocaine into the United States for years. As Secretary of State, he has put drug dealers into every pro-US government on the continent. Unsurprisingly, some are saying that the assault could actually be a Rubio move to defend US-sponsored drug-runners against the more autonomous dealers who also exist in that part of the world.

Another irony is that Delta Force, the US state-terrorist special forces team that abducted the Venezuelan president, is itself widely regarded as operating a drug-trafficking network within the United States. The investigative journalist Seth Harp's *The Fort Bragg Cartel: Drug Trafficking and Murder in the Special Forces* (2025) documents murder and narcotics trafficking committed in and around the US Army installation outside of Fayetteville, North Carolina. Harp's book made it onto the *New York Times* bestseller list and reviewers have largely accepted its findings. So this criminal US operation was carried out by its own drug cartel. There's no sense of shame here, or anything like that. They just do it, assuming people will keep on taking this as long as they can point to a few successes.

We now have Attorney General Pam Bondi tweeting the so-called indictments, which have a touch of insanity about them:

Nicolas Maduro and his wife, Cilia Flores, have been indicted in the Southern District of New York. Nicolas Maduro has been charged with Narco-Terrorism Conspiracy, Cocaine Importation Conspiracy, Possession of Machineguns and Destructive Devices, and Conspiracy to Possess Machineguns and Destructive Devices against the United States.

No serious lawyer in the United States could take this at face value. The whole thing is a farce. To accuse a sitting president, whom you've just kidnapped while bombing his capital, of 'conspiracy to possess' automatic weapons is grotesque. Bondi is setting up a show trial, but it may not be as easy as she thinks. Without any doubt, some of the best US lawyers will defend Maduro and take up his case. This does indicate, however, that appointments to the second Trump cabinet were largely made on the basis of loyalty rather than competence — selecting people who wouldn't question the President and his crazy ideas — as the interview with Trump's chief of staff in *Vanity Fair* makes clear. The absence of any serious opposition in the country capable of insisting on the authority of

Congress suggests a process of decay within the institutions of American bourgeois democracy itself.

Many have pointed out — as Chávez himself noted — that this is the Noriega script. But there is an important sense in which Maduro, whatever his weaknesses, cannot be compared to Noriega. The Panamanian strongman had effectively worked for the CIA since the 1950s, gunrunning for right-wing groups heavily involved in the drug trade, before he fell out with Washington. He had been trained in torture at the notorious School of the Americas, where countless racketeers and drug-trafficking money-launderers had their first experience of what was required of them. The US treated him extremely badly, despite everything he had done for them. He began to get one or two ideas about national sovereignty, at which point the government of George H. W. Bush angrily decided to oust him. That operation, however, was backed by a US military invasion, before a joint Delta-SEAL detachment lifted him from his palace and handed him over to US Marshals to be locked up after a fake trial.

But there is another precedent, which should not be forgotten: that of Jean-Bertrand Aristide, President of Haiti in the early 1990s and then again from his election in 2001 until his overthrow in 2004. Initially a moderate, Aristide had the nerve to say that Haiti should be repaid by France for the massive reparations the island had been forced to pay its former colonial master for the crime of abolishing slavery after the 1791–1804 Haitian Revolution — some \$21 billion in today's money. Paris worried that this might set a precedent for Algerian demands. In February 2004, French and Haitian officials collaborated with the US to force Aristide out of the country.

There's an interesting footnote here. In spring 2004 I happened to be at a conference in Caracas when this Franco-American operation was taking place. The day after Aristide's abduction, I said to Chávez: 'Why didn't you offer him asylum?' He said: 'I feel incredibly upset. He was trying to ring me, and we were busy with the

conference. By the time I got the message, it was too late. He'd already been sent off to South Africa, and I regret it.' I told him that I was going to Johannesburg soon to give a lecture. Chávez said: 'Please try and meet him and tell him he's very welcome here. He should be back in his own region to fight back against these rogues.' I did, in fact, send the message. But I think Pretoria had a deal that he was to be kept in South Africa until the US allowed him to return to Haiti. Maduro is the latest in a long line.

The attacks against him recall the assaults on Chávez, continually accused by the Western media of being a dictator. Why? Because he wore a uniform. But Chávez was extremely popular and won election after election; one didn't have to go down to the Gulf States and Saudi Arabia to find people infinitely worse on every level. Chávez's radical-democratic constitution — including the right to recall the president by referendum, if necessary — was denounced by the right-wing opposition, even though it then tried to use the same recall mechanism against him. I was in Caracas when Jimmy Carter visited the country to observe the elections. He was shocked when, entering a restaurant in the leafy eastern suburbs of the city, where the bourgeoisie lives, the local opposition spat abuse at him. Afterwards he said, 'I've never seen an opposition like this anywhere'. When asked, 'How did you think the elections went?', he answered that he hadn't seen such a fair election in any country, clearly including the United States.

Chávez always insisted that the Bolivarian Revolution must be a democratic experience — and it was. Many people, including myself, discussed this with him. When the first results came in for the 2004 referendum, I asked Chávez, '*Compañero*, what are we going to do if we lose?' He said, 'What do you do if you lose? You leave office and fight again from outside, explaining why they were wrong'. He had a very strong sense of this. Which is why it's a travesty to accuse the *Chavistas* of being anti-democratic from the start. During the Chávez period, the opposition newspapers and television stations blasted propaganda non-stop, attacking the regime — some-

thing you could never have seen in Britain or the United States. When people said to Chávez, ‘We should crack down’, he said, ‘No, we fight them politically’.

Since 2013, the regime has been hollowed out. If Maduro won the 2024 election, he was not able to provide any proof of it when asked by Lula. Economically, there’s no doubt that the Bolivarians were ill-advised, even during the Chávez days. When the best Keynesian economists turned up there, including Dean Baker and Mark Weisbrot, as well as Joseph Stiglitz, their recommendations weren’t followed. Possibly it would have been better at that point if they had turned to the Chinese. But the real economic deterioration was a result of the US siege. The sanctions on oil sales, imposed by Trump in 2017-18 and maintained by Biden, effectively led to some 7 million people leaving the country, with Venezuelan refugees turning up in Miami, Colombia and other parts of Latin America. Washington knew what it was doing.

The support of the Venezuelan armed forces also came at a cost. After the 2002 coup attempt against Chávez, I said to him, ‘This is your chance to go for a massive restructuring of the Army’. But he said, ‘It’s not easy to do. We’re getting rid of all the senior generals who knew of or were involved in the coup attempt against me’. So I said, ‘Well, that’s actually very generous of you, because had such a coup attempt been made against an elected government in the United States, it’s very likely that the top general would have been executed for treason and the other generals would have been locked up for years. But you’ve been very kind, you’ve let some of these guys go out.’ He said, ‘Better to have the smell away’. It was a weakness, I felt at the time.

Yet for a long period, the Bolivarian regime combined radical democracy, far-reaching social-welfare and literacy programmes and an internationalist foreign policy. That was the constellation. The Cuban contribution was very important, the *misiones* and the rest of it. But the Cubans had no lessons to teach on democracy, alas. As the economic siege tightened, Caracas abandoned virtually

all the *Chavista* reforms, turning to dollarization and austerity from 2019. On foreign policy, however, they didn't go that route. They have cut down a lot on the oil to Cuba as a result of US sanctions, but they haven't abandoned Havana. They maintained a tough position on Gaza and the Middle East, which obviously annoys the Americans. As Washington has made clear, they want a Rubio–Trump government which is theirs, 100 per cent.



At the official level, international reaction has been predictably muted. Naturally, China, Russia and many other powers have condemned the US military attack and abduction, calling for Maduro and Flores's immediate release. After some dithering the Europeans have rallied in support of their protector, albeit with a shade more ambivalence than they displayed in backing the Israeli genocide in Gaza. Macron initially put out a statement calling on Venezuelans to 'rejoice' at Maduro's abduction, then had second thoughts and issued another saying that France 'neither supported nor approved' US methods, before characteristically putting out a third, looking forward to a peaceful transition to a Venezuela led by Edmundo González Urrutia. Merz judges the legality of the kidnapping to be 'complex'. Starmer too has been evasive, mumbling about 'support for international law' while avoiding any criticism of Trump.

Double standards the citizens of Europe are used to. Russia on the one side, against whom the EU is preparing their twentieth package of sanctions; and Israel on the other, which maintains its status of favoured nation. And now there's a third, triple standard — the attack on Venezuela. By comparison, the attitude of *The New York Times* is more forthright, calling the operation an instance of 'latter-day imperialism', representing 'a dangerous and illegal approach to America's place in the world.' It cites Republican legisla-

tors who have spoken out against Trump's course in Congress — Senators Rand Paul and Lisa Murkowski, Representatives Thomas Massie and Don Bacon.

There may be further mobilizations in the United States itself. The new mayor of New York, Zohran Mamdani, denounced the unilateral attack on a sovereign nation as an act of war, and there have already been protests in eight US cities. Solidarity with the Bolivarian Republic is crucial. At stake is not only the future of Venezuela but also that of the Cuban Revolution — the first, and alas it would appear last, socialist revolution in the Americas. Cuba has been battered and besieged by the United States: one invasion defeated at Playa Girón, constant sanctions, constant attacks, constant lies. Without Venezuelan oil, supplied free since the Bolivarians came to power, there is reason to fear for Cuba's future. And if the US succeeds in 'cleaning up' Venezuela, Cuba may well be next.

But this may prove harder than expected. The demonstrations in Caracas should serve as a warning to the Trump Administration. Over the last few days, Rodríguez has been alternating between militant speeches, attacking what has happened, and reassuring noises to the Americans. Trump is saying, 'We're not interested in what she says, we're interested in what she does'. He's right. A lot will depend, not so much on her, because she's just a figurehead, but on the Venezuelan Army, which is absolutely crucial.

The Trump Administration could be faced with a dilemma. The Bolivarians still control the Venezuelan military and paramilitary forces, the courts, the oil industry and every level of the administrative bureaucracy. Emotions are running high, as the message delivered to the Venezuelan National Assembly by Maduro's son made clear. The Rodríguez government has been negotiating, as we know. But if Trump and Rubio ramp up the pressure too far, given the general hostility to the US attack, Caracas may be forced into some show of resistance. If Rodríguez and company refuse to play ball at some point, Trump might be capable of shrugging it off, but

the Rubio camp will not be. At that stage, the logic of treating Caracas as a puppet government could break down and the line will be, ‘Okay, they’re traitors, let’s go and grab them’ — finally sending in boots on the ground. That would get messy, fast. It would also cause enormous tensions within Trump’s own camp, because this is one thing he repeatedly pledged not to do.

In Chávez’s 2005 speech, he went on to say:

Fidel once told me, ‘Chávez, if that ever happens to you or me, if they invade us, the last thing we’d do is what Saddam did: go and hide in a hole. You have to die fighting, in the first line of battle.’ And that’s what I would do — if I have to die, I’ll die on the front line with the dignity of a Venezuelan who loves this country.

Nothing is settled as yet.

This piece first appeared on 5 January 2026 in New Left Review, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

We're a superpower, and under President Trump, we are going to conduct ourselves as a superpower. It is absurd that we would allow a nation in our own backyard to become the supplier of resources to our adversaries but not to us... We are in charge because we have the United States military stationed outside the country. We set the terms and conditions. We have a complete embargo on all of their oil and their ability to do commerce.

— *Stephen Miller, deputy White House chief of staff and Homeland Security adviser*

Mokhiber on UN Security Council Abomination

The UN Embraces Colonialism: Unpacking the Security Council's mandate for the U.S. colonial administration of Gaza

Craig Mokhiber

More than two years into the genocide in Palestine, the UN Security Council has finally acted. But rather than acting to enforce international law, protect the victims, and hold the perpetrators accountable, it adopted a resolution that openly flouts key provisions of international law, disempowers and further punishes the victims, and rewards and empowers the perpetrators.

Most disturbingly, it hands control of Gaza and the survivors of the genocide over to the United States, a co-perpetrator of the genocide, and provides for the participation of the Israeli regime in decision making. Under the plan, Palestinians themselves are to be granted no such participation in decisions on their own rights, governance, and lives.

In adopting this resolution, the Council, in effect, has become a mechanism of U.S. oppression, an instrument for the continued unlawful occupation of Palestine, and a complicit actor in Israel's genocide.

Not since the UN partitioned Palestine in 1947 against the will of the indigenous people, setting the stage for 80 years of Nakba, has the UN acted in such a baldly colonial — and legally *ultra vires* — way, and trampled so recklessly on the rights of a people.

This piece first appeared on 18 November 2025 in Mondoweiss, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

Gaza Tribunal Jury of Conscience

Final Statement — Istanbul, October 26, 2025

The Jury of Conscience

We, the undersigned members of the Jury of Conscience, hereby deliver this Statement of Findings and Moral Judgment at the final session of the Gaza Tribunal. The Jury, guided by conscience and informed by international law, does not speak with the authority of states, but when law is silenced by power, conscience must become the final tribunal.

The Tribunal is not a court of law so does not purport to determine guilt or liability of any person, organization or state. It is a civil society response to the continuing lack of accountability for the commission by Israel of genocide in the Gaza Strip. We believe that genocide must be named and documented and that impunity feeds continuing violence throughout the globe. Genocide in Gaza is the concern of all humanity. When states are silent civil society can and must speak out.

The Gaza Tribunal has brought together a wealth of material in a valuable archive, the existence of which provides lasting evidence of the truth of the genocide against the Palestinian people. The Jury expresses solidarity with the rallies, the marches, the encampments, the flotillas, the strikes and other actions that protest the genocide and states' unwillingness to hold Israel to account. And it offers a counter-narrative to the security narrative Israel and its allies persistently broadcast and to the labelling of Palestinian suffering as a humanitarian disaster. It is not. It is the deliberate commission of the gravest of crimes, imposed with dire humanitarian consequences.

We have heard extensive evidence of the crimes committed by Israel, of the causes of the genocide, of the collusion by and complicity of other actors, of courageous resistance and resilience by Palestinians and by global civil society. We have heard moving personal testimonies of the physical and mental harms wrought by these crimes and the suffering of the Palestinian people.

This concluding statement presents our findings based upon this evidence and the legal standards of the Genocide Convention, the human rights treaties, the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court, and the moral imperatives of natural justice. Yet above all, this decision is grounded in the unyielding belief that every human life has equal worth, and that no state or ideology has the right to destroy an entire people.

Our decision builds upon the testimonies, oral and written, the expert evidence and the research and analytical papers carried out by many people over the past months. It reiterates and endorses the Sarajevo Declaration adopted in May 2025.

Israel's Crimes

The Jury condemns the ongoing genocide and crimes listed below. We believe these crimes and their impact on the Palestinian people should be separately named to understand the holistic nature of the genocide, its dehumanisation of the people, its sadistic character, and its temporality. These crimes did not commence in October 2023 and they will not end with the ceasefire; deaths and severe physical harm will continue. The physical and psychological trauma of the surviving population will be transmitted through the generations.

The Jury condemns the commission of the following additional crimes:

Starvation and famine through the deliberate denial of food, water and systematic destruction of the entire food system.

Domicide is more than the intentional mass destruction of residential properties and their infrastructure — electricity, water and sanitation. A home is about love, life, a repository of memories, hopes and aspiration. Its destruction causes displacement, trauma, the disintegration of communities, and profound cultural loss.

Ecocide describes a particular kind of warfare based on ruination of land fertility, air quality, sources of food and water: catastrophic environmental damage that destroys the capacity to survive after the bombing ceases.

Deliberate destruction and targeting of healthcare infrastructure, equipment, and personnel have been systematic for decades and has become almost total. The most important issue for physical and mental health is the Israeli occupation and the dehumanisation of the population.

Reproicide is the intentional and systematic targeting of Palestinian reproductive care through prevention of births, eliminating future lives, and the ability to reproduce safely.

Scholasticide is the genocide of knowledge, the destruction of Palestine's intellectual future through the killing, silencing and displacing a generation of students and teachers, obliteration of schools and universities, destroying dreams and aspirations.

Attacks on journalists. 'Genocide documentation' is carried out by Palestinian journalists and they and their families are targeted. Silencing these journalists is instrumental to the concealment of the genocide and more journalists have been killed than in any other conflict.

Torture, sexual violence, disappearances, gender-based violence in detention, at checkpoints, in house searches, in displacement, and elsewhere.

Politicide is the targeted assassination and kidnapping of political and cultural leaders, representatives, activists, and destruction of civic institutions.

The Jury finds a coherent and consistent pattern of exterminatory violence in the intentional and targeted destruction of homes,

water supplies, schools, hospitals, clinics, universities, cultural and religious institutions, agricultural land, and natural ecosystems. The weaponization of hunger, denial of medical care, and forced displacement are not collateral damages of war — they are instruments of collective punishment of the entire population and of genocide. They are not justified by any claim of military objectives.

Complicity and Collusion

The Jury finds Western governments, particularly the United States, and others complicit in, in some cases colluding with, Israel's commission of genocide through provision of diplomatic cover, weapons, weapon parts, intelligence, military assistance and training, and continuing economic relations. Such actions constitute moral failure and breach of their legal duty to prevent genocide and to cooperate to end a violation of a peremptory norm of international law — genocide and the Palestinian right to self-determination. Silence and inaction in the face of genocide are not an option and are other forms of complicity.

The Jury finds a range of non-state actors to be complicit in genocide. Biased media reporting in the west on Palestine and under-reporting of Israeli crimes conform to the economic and political interest of the ruling elites and their allied interests. Academic institutions through their investments support Israel; staff and student endorsements of Palestine are silenced or disciplined.

Israel survives through militarisation; global supply chains sustain the genocide through weapons, banks, technology, transportation, and other multinational corporations. The hi-technology sector sustains the machinery of genocide by manipulating contents through algorithms, and allowing Israel to watch and plan every airstrike and assassination. Companies that sell cloud capacity to Israel provide the computer power for genocide. The Jury consid-

ers that the political economy of genocide is the highest form of hyper imperialism of the 21st century.

The Jury finds the current global order, structured by power hierarchies and economic dependencies, to have revealed its incapacity to prevent or punish atrocity crimes when committed by the powerful or their allies. The United Nations, paralyzed by the veto and political selectivity, has abdicated its foundational responsibility “to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war.”

The Jury however commends the UNHRC special procedures, including the Commission of Inquiry and especially the steadfastness of the special rapporteur on the occupied Palestinian territories, Francesca Albanese, for their affirmation of genocide.

Conclusions

The Jury affirms that Israel is perpetrating an ongoing genocide against the Palestinian people in Gaza, within — and enabled by — a broader settler-colonial apartheid regime rooted in the supremacist ideology of Zionism. This campaign is inseparable from over a century-long project targeting Palestinians across all of Palestine and in exile. The root causes of genocide lie in a racist, supremacist ideology — Zionism — that underpins a system aiming to dispossess, dominate, and erase Palestinians, supported by an oppressive neo-colonial power structure led by the United States and its allies, and shielded by international complicity, including from many governments.

The Jury considers the genocide in Gaza to have several exceptional characteristics. It is perpetuated on a captive population in a tiny, closed territory where Israel controls all entries and exits. It is systematic and carried out with the most advanced technology. Despite Israel’s attempts to prevent reporting, it is highly visible in real time. There has been resort to international judicial bodies — the International Court of Justice by South Africa, the request for an Advisory Opinion by the UN General Assembly with respect to

UNRWA, and the arrest warrants issued by the ICC — yet these have been ignored with impunity by Israel and other states have made little real protest and minimal sanctions have been imposed. Indeed, it is the ICC personnel and NGOs assisting the Court that have been sanctioned by the United States.

Recommendations

ENDING IMPUNITY AND ENSURING ACCOUNTABILITY

To hold all those responsible, politically, militarily, economically, and ideologically — perpetrators, supporters, enablers, and complicit parties — fully accountable by every lawful means and to the fullest extent of the law.

To suspend Israel from international organizations and institutions, particularly the United Nations and its affiliates.

To activate UN General Assembly Resolution 377 A(V) (Uniting for Peace) so the UNGA can adopt collective measures to mandate a protective force for the Palestinian territories and stop the genocide in Gaza, given the UNSC's failure to act due to successive U.S. vetoes.

RESISTING AND DISMANTLING OPPRESSIVE STRUCTURES

The Jury reaffirms the right of the Palestinian people to self-determination and to choose their modes of resistance to achieve liberation, freedom, and independence.

The Jury endorses a global, rights-based strategy to dismantle Zionist structures: identify and map the Zionist regime's sources of power and enabling pillars.

The Jury calls for building a worldwide movement that weakens, isolates, and dismantles each source through coordinated political, legal, economic, academic, cultural, technological, and social action.

To achieve this objective, two main tasks are paramount:

Steadfastness and non-displacement. Palestinians — in Gaza, the West Bank including Jerusalem, and Palestinian communities inside the 1948 lines — must remain rooted in their land. There must be no further forced displacement of Palestinians in exile, particularly refugees across the region. Preventing displacement and sustaining steadfastness are essential to maintain the struggle.

Comprehensive global confrontation. Confront the Zionist movement and regime globally in every sphere — political and diplomatic; legal and human rights; economic and commercial; media, cultural, intellectual, academic, and educational; industrial, technological, and scientific; arts, tourism, and sports. This mobilization centers peoples, movements, parties, unions, civil-society organizations, and individuals so that solidarity becomes power, normalization is resisted, and the Zionist project is besieged on all fronts.

The Jury affirms that the struggle is with Zionism as a racist, supremacist, settler-colonial enterprise — not with Jews or Judaism. The strategic horizon is a single rights-based political order grounded in equality, decolonization, restitution, and the unfettered right of return. Only this course can end the ongoing genocide and open a path to a just and durable peace for all who live in Palestine and beyond.

We issue this statement in the name of justice, dignity, and peace, and in remembrance of all those who have perished in Gaza and throughout Palestine.

Silence is not neutral; silence is complicity; neutrality is surrender to evil.

In solidarity with the people of Gaza and in memory of all victims of genocide,

The Jury of Conscience (alphabetically)

- Prof. Sami Al-Arian
- Prof. Christine Chinkin

- Dr. Ghada Karmi
- Author Kenize Mourad
- Prof. Chandra Muzaffar
- Prof. Biljana Vankovska

TESTIMONY

My Testimony at the Gaza Tribunal in Istanbul

May 26–29, 2025

Maura Finkelstein

My name is Maura Finkelstein and, until May 2024, I was a tenured professor of anthropology at Muhlenberg College, in Allentown, Pennsylvania. I am here in my capacity as an expert in university complicity in genocide, and in the ten minutes I have, I will show how colleges and universities in the United States have actively supported Israel's U.S.-backed genocide in Gaza through three features of university complicity: first, university investments, second, university partnerships, and third, university silencing of dissent.

Before I begin, I note that my testimony is drawn from the U.S. context, where my expertise lies. However, I would argue that — across the world — every institution that hasn't expressly divested from Israel, clearly condemned genocide and scholasticide, and unequivocally supported students, faculty, and staff who are supporting Palestinian liberation, is complicit in this genocide.

The jury should also be aware that this work of silencing speech and action in support of Palestinian liberation and in opposition to this genocide is part of a much larger and longer assault on our campuses because they offer a space of solidarity, radical possibility, organizing, and community care despite — and because of — the university's evolution towards corporate and authoritarian structure. It is against this backdrop that we have watched these last two years of violent repression unfold.

Feature One: University Investments

Most colleges and universities are not transparent about their economic partnerships. So students use the slogan, “disclose, divest” to demand that administrations, boards of trustees, and boards of regents first disclose their investments and then unload investments in companies that are directly aiding in the dispossession, ethnic cleansing, and genocide of Palestine.

Acknowledging the general refusal of university administrations to disclose, a vast majority of American colleges and universities, on one hand, directly support genocide through investments in Israel and weapons manufacturing and, on the other, indirectly support genocide through investments in companies as revealed in Special Rapporteur Francesca Albanese’s report, “From economy of occupation to economy of genocide” — like Google and Amazon, which provide technology services to Israel’s military; Airbnb, which allows for rental listings in illegal Israeli settlements in the West Bank; and Caterpillar, whose equipment Israel’s military uses to destroy homes and crush Palestinians and their allies.

We must also take account of philanthropic support — U.S. universities depend on corporate funding and billionaire donors, which results in stakeholders who have the power to determine the educational policy and ideological brand of these institutions, as well as where the institutions invest their funds.

Feature Two: University Partnerships

Colleges and universities in the U.S. consistently partner with those in Israel to build and cement ties through study abroad and student exchange programs. As Maya Wind’s research reveals, these are all institutions that serve the State of Israel’s projects of occupation, apartheid, and settler colonial genocide.

Additionally, organizations like Hillel International not only host and organize such exchanges, they also facilitate birthright

trips and hasbara fellowships for students and, most egregiously, 65 colleges and universities across the U.S. take part in the Israel Fellows Program, which brings former Israeli soldiers to campus to forge deeper ties between American students and Israel. These fellows also aid in the harassment, surveillance, and intimidation of Palestinian and anti-Zionist students, faculty, and staff.

Of further concern are research collaborations. As one example, since World War II and solidifying and expanding during the Cold War, U.S. universities have collaborated with the military and aerospace sectors — the “military-industrial-academic complex” — including what the Department of Defense calls “University Affiliated Research Centers (UARC)s,” a program begun in 1996 to develop “essential engineering and technology capabilities.” There are 15 UARC schools in the U.S. One of them, the University of Southern California, also provides human cadavers to the U.S. and Israeli military for trauma surgery training for Israeli soldiers.

Feature Three: University Silencing of Dissent

In order to protect their investments and partnerships in Israel and its genocide, colleges and universities have been actively and violently silencing dissent and foreclosing spaces of solidarity.

An example of this is university overreach. Columbia University has infamously led the way in normalizing repression and silencing dissent on college and university campuses. We’ve seen this with President Minouche Shafik’s congressional hearing in Spring 2024, where she revealed that she dismissed or removed five faculty members from the classroom and suspended 15 students and two student groups — Students for Justice in Palestine and Jewish Voice for Peace — from campus. She then incorrectly categorized both “from the river to the sea” and “globalize the intifada” as hate speech.

Across the US, college and university administrators, following Columbia, are now partnering with Zionist organizations like

Hillel International, the Anti-Defamation League, and AIPAC, to run campus “antisemitism trainings”, which, drawing on the IHRA definition of antisemitism, categorizes advocating for Palestinian liberation and condemning Israel’s genocide in Gaza with “hate speech.”

Another example is how administrations are silencing and endangering students. The Gaza Solidarity Encampments are the most explicit demonstration.

As part of the steady neoliberal shift over the past 40 years, college and university administrators across the U.S. have worked hand in glove with the police to dismantle student encampments and brutalize and incarcerate students — and some faculty and staff — who have been part of the encampment movements.

Some of the worst violence occurred at Columbia University, with the administration-sanctioned police attack on Hind’s Hall, and at UCLA, where administrators and police stood back as Zionist and white supremacist mobs brutalized students in the middle of the night. Across the U.S., every single one of these violent acts of repression occurred under the direction and oversight of college and university leadership.

This silencing of dissent by college and university administrators has led to collaborations with ICE and the Trump Administration, and these violences have only escalated.

As of May 2025, the Middle East Studies Association’s Academic Freedom Initiative has tracked 1,708 cases involving visa revocations and terminations of immigration records, entry denials, deportations, and detentions of university students, faculty, and staff.

While the most well-known case is that of Mahmoud Khalil, I want to draw attention to two political prisoners, Leqaa Kordia and Casey Goonan, who are still in detention because of their anti-genocide activism and support for Palestinian liberation. Free Leqaa, free Casey.

Lastly, I would like to draw the jury’s attention to how administrations are suspending and terminating faculty and staff. Over the

past two years, the Department of Education released a list of over 100 schools under investigation by the Office of Civil Rights for potential violations of Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964.

Numerous university administrations — famously among them Harvard University, Columbia University, and my former employer, Muhlenberg College — have responded to and exacerbated this situation by conflating political criticism of Israel and Zionism with antisemitism and using this to suspend and fire faculty and staff.

Once again drawing on the Middle East Studies Association's research, the Academic Freedom Initiative has created a database that tracks all adverse employment outcomes for university employees who have advocated for Palestine since October 2023. Thus far, they have recorded 61 cases of retaliation, including suspensions, terminations, forced resignations, rescinded offers, and removals from service positions, across 37 colleges and universities. I am one of those faculty.

The number of faculty and staff who are targets continues to grow. These ongoing repressive measures by college and university administrators have created a chilling effect across higher education, as many academics are now choosing to self-censor, cancel classes, refrain from publishing and posting on social media, and omit materials about Palestine to avoid investigation.

Conclusions

I've thus far talked about how institutions of higher education across the United States have directly defended and justified Israel's genocide in Gaza. More insidiously, within academic spaces, many university workers have elided the real stakes of settler colonial genocide, ethnic cleansing, and land dispossession by fabricating, circulating, and normalizing "both sides" rhetoric on our campuses.

These institutions cannot bring the dead back nor can they undo the damage of Israel's destruction. But at a minimum, and echoing Rania Muhareb's call on Thursday, we must demand that these institutions completely divest from weapons manufacturers, all militaries, and companies aiding and abetting genocide, as well as the Israeli State. Additionally, U.S. institutions of higher education must dissolve partnerships and exchanges with Israeli institutions and ban Zionist watchdog organizations like Hillel International and the ADL from spaces of influence on campuses.

But this is not enough — every institution with financial ties to the Israeli State should pledge that number (and more) to Gaza, as Palestinians rebuild the world we in the West have been so active in destroying. While these reparations are not enough, they are at least a start.

Some Thoughts on Trump's Gaza 'Peace Plan'

Faramarz Farbod

On October 10, President Trump's "Peace plan" brought forth a fragile ceasefire in Gaza, the third since October 7, 2023. Israel had violated the previous two and has violated this one multiple times. For example, on October 19, it launched an assault on Gaza, claiming retaliation for a Hamas attack that killed two Israeli soldiers. Hamas denied responsibility. Later reports suggested the soldiers' vehicle struck unexploded ordnance. By then, Israeli airstrikes were already devastating Gaza's neighborhoods, threatening to shatter the fragile ceasefire.

The Israeli violations aside, the main clauses of Trump's plan are: a call for ceasefire; Hamas to release all living and dead Israeli captives in exchange for Israel freeing roughly 2,000 Palestinian "prisoners" (out of more than 11,000 held in Israeli jails), including returning fifteen dead Palestinian hostages for every one dead Israeli captive; Israel to lift its blockade of humanitarian aid; Gaza's governance to pass to a nonpolitical administration while Israeli troops withdraw in stages; and Hamas is disarmed.

The first phase of the plan has already been completed: so far, a fragile ceasefire is holding despite the multiple Israeli violations; the captives and hostages have been exchanged, short of several hard-to-get-to bodies of dead Israeli captives remaining under rubble of bombed-out buildings and tunnels; though only about 15% of the promised aid has reached Gaza, nowhere close to the level needed or envisioned in the plan. Reportedly, there are negotiations currently underway on the tougher remaining issues, such as who governs Gaza, who pays for reconstruction, whether Hamas

will disarm, whether Israel will fully withdraw its forces, and whether Israel will lift its 18-year-long brutal siege of Gaza.

Hamas has agreed to a transfer of governance to an independent Palestinian administration while insisting that the issue of political representation be settled within an inclusive Palestinian national framework. As in the past, Hamas has linked the question of disarmament to the question of Palestinian statehood. It is unlikely that it will change this position. Israel, of course, can be counted on to oppose any demand for Palestinian sovereignty and to look for every opportunity to violate or derail the ceasefire.

The Trump plan's conditions, at first glance, look comprehensive. Yet, like so many US initiatives before it, the plan avoids the central question: the political rights of Palestinians and the existence of a sovereign Palestinian state. Without addressing those, any truce will collapse, regardless of how much Trump insists on conflating a ceasefire with peace. To be exact, the plan acknowledges Palestinian self-determination but only as a distant "aspiration of the Palestinian people" to be attended to, if at all, in a post-reconstructed Gaza — the latter now reduced to a vast graveyard of tens of thousands, if not hundreds of thousands, of Gazans, with nearly all of its infrastructure destroyed, and more than 50 million tons of rubble, the removal of which the UN has estimated will take a quarter century to complete.

It is important to note that Palestinian self-determination is not limited to Gaza and includes the Palestinians living in East Jerusalem and under military occupation in the West Bank. The latter have been subjected to intensified and vicious settler attacks and pogroms since Apartheid Israel's genocidal attacks in Gaza after October 7, 2023. Indeed, Israel's Knesset voted on October 22 in favor of annexing the West Bank just as Trump's VP Vance was visiting Israel.

The question of annexing the West Bank can be consequential. The reactionary Arab allies of the US have made it clear that annexing the West Bank is one of their red lines, potentially stopping

them from normalizing relations with Israel through joining the Abraham Accords. This is Saudi Arabia's declared position, a key country whose normalization through joining the Abraham Accords is most sought after by Trump. This fact may explain VP Vance and Sec. of State Rubio promptly proclaiming the US opposition to the Knesset vote. We will have to see how serious the US is in opposing the annexation of the West Bank.

What is clear, however, is that Trump has not called for ending the occupation of the West Bank and the removal of more than 700,000 settlers in some 160 Jewish-only settlements established on stolen Palestinian land. The same goes for East Jerusalem and the creeping Judaization ("de-Arabization") policies of Israel. Of course, no one is addressing the issue of the Right of Return of the by now seven million Palestinian refugees either, an issue inseparable from any meaningful consideration of Palestinian rights.

To be clear, then, the deeper problem is conceptual. President Trump, like many US leaders before him, mistakes the silencing of guns — though not entirely silenced, as Israel has killed and injured several hundred Palestinians since the ceasefire went into effect on October 10 — for peace itself. But a ceasefire is not peace: it is a pause. True peace requires confronting the structures of occupation, siege, dispossession, discrimination, rightlessness, and displacement that perpetuate violence. His plan, for all its clauses, leaves the core system of settler colonialism untouched with all that it requires in terms of domination, ethnic cleansing, and genocide — slow or massive.

Israel will likely continue to choke Gaza's surviving people with its blockade and ability to restrict aid convoys. It is unclear whether Washington will use the means at its disposal to press Israel to stop annexing West Bank territory beyond the urgings by VP Vance and Sec. of State Rubio to stop. Meanwhile, regional mediators and Palestinian factions are meeting to outline a post-genocide political framework. There is a broad agreement among Palestinian factions that Gaza's next phase of governance must be

Palestinian, with no separation between the Gaza Strip and the West Bank. Discussions even include the possibility of UN peacekeepers, an idea the US and Israel strongly oppose, but one that could protect civilians.

In sum, real peace demands justice, accountability, and equality of rights. Gazans are in desperate conditions. As winter is approaching, they face hunger, homelessness, and despair. They need food, medicine, and safety. Trump's version of "peace" may fill headlines, but peace rooted in justice — the kind envisioned by movements for liberation and echoed by activists everywhere — is the only peace that lasts.

The world is so used to us being killed and tortured by Israel that it has forgotten that at the end of the day, we are humans who want nothing more than to live a normal life, safe in our homeland.

— *Plestia Alaqqad, journalist and author of The Eyes of Gaza: A Diary of Resilience*

The UN Has Voted to Put the Occupation of Iraq in Charge of Gaza

David Swanson

Ah, those were the days. The UN had been blocked by a worldwide popular movement from approving of a war on Iraq. British Prime Minister Tony Blair had dragged the UK along after secretly demanding that George W. Bush first attack Afghanistan, because Blair believed he would be better able to sell a war on Iraq once there was a war on Afghanistan. And once the destruction of Iraq was well underway, the UN crept out of some New York sewer pipe to support the occupation — er, excuse me, the peaceful transition to paradise.

Fun fact: no war has ever been launched by people doing everything possible to avoid it. Bonus fun fact: no modern war has ever been launched by people not claiming they were doing everything possible to avoid it.

The United Nations has now voted — the “Security” Council that is, with Russia and China abstaining, as if they have some other planet to live on — for an Orwellian “Peace Board” concocted by Donald Trump, to be run by Tony Blair, to oversee a military occupation of what’s left of Gaza.

This piece first appeared on 17 November 2025 in World BEYOND War, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

The Return Home

What is home during a genocide?

Maura Finkelstein

What is home during a genocide? Almost all of Gaza’s built environment has been decimated — by January 2025, UNRWA and MSF reported that 92% of homes in Gaza had been destroyed by the Zionist military. Now, that number is likely close to 100% of homes either entirely or partially destroyed.

Two weeks ago at the Gaza tribunal, Balakrishnan Rajagopal, Special Rapporteur on the Right to Adequate Housing, spoke on a panel about domicide, which he defines as “the mass destruction of housing, residential buildings, homes, property, and civilian infrastructure,” and explained that it is “the most visible, recorded, and unique element of the war on Gaza since 2023.” He clarified: “When such domicide is systematic and widespread and accompanied by genocidal intent, it constitutes war crimes, crimes against humanity, and genocide.”

Mohamed Al Helou, a journalist based in Gaza, also spoke on that panel. He reminded us that the story of a house is also the story of the 14 people who live in that house, the cats who live with them, the trees who surround them, the oranges they harvest and eat in the summer. A house is the marks on the walls, the pictures on the shelves. Every home is an archive, every home holds a story.

This piece first appeared on 5 November 2025 in Maura Finkelstein's Substack, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

Wars do not end when the bombs stop falling. They linger in the minds of those who survive and in the void left by those who do not. For Palestinians, the war is never over — ceasefire is merely the space between tragedies. And in that space, we carry with us the unbearable weight of memories that cannot be undone.... A cease-fire might stop the missiles, but the trauma remains.

— *Plestia Alaqqad, journalist and author of The Eyes of Gaza: A Diary of Resilience*

A Calculated Attempt to Erase the Horizon of Palestinian Liberation

Statement from the Cabinet of the Progressive International on the UN Security Council resolution on Gaza

Cabinet of the Progressive International

The Cabinet of the Progressive International condemns the United Nations Security Council resolution authorizing a colonial governance structure in Gaza — a calculated attempt to erase the horizon of Palestinian liberation.

On 17 November 2025, the UN Security Council voted through a resolution endorsing a plan — first put forward by Donald Trump and Benjamin Netanyahu on 25 September — to establish sweeping foreign control over Gaza. The resolution passed with 13 votes in favor and two abstentions.

A so-called Board of Peace, to be chaired personally by Donald Trump, is granted overarching power over reconstruction, governance, and humanitarian aid — aims that conceal within them imperialism's drive to extract further profit from the genocidal destruction it has caused. The Board would neither be accountable to the Palestinian people nor bound by the UN.

This piece first appeared on 10 November 2025 in Progressive International, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

AI for War: Big Tech Empowering Israel's Crimes and Occupation

Marwa Fatafta

US technology giants portray themselves as architects of a better world powered by artificial intelligence, cloud computing, and data-driven solutions. Under slogans such as “AI for Good,” they pledge to serve as ethical stewards of the technologies reshaping our societies. Yet in Gaza, these narratives have collapsed, alongside international norms and what remains of the so-called rules-based order.

Central to Israel’s AI warfare is Project Nimbus — a \$1.2 billion contract through which Google and Amazon have provided the Israeli government and military with advanced cloud infrastructure and machine learning capabilities. In the early days of the genocide, Israeli forces reportedly relied almost entirely on AI-powered target-generating systems — such as Lavender, The Gospel, and Where’s Daddy — to accelerate mass killing and destruction across Gaza. These platforms ingest mass surveillance data about the entire population of Gaza to algorithmically determine, at scale, who is to be killed, which buildings are to be bombed, and how much “collateral damage” is deemed acceptable.

In a grim evolution, the deployment of commercial AI in Gaza marks a chilling frontier: systems once designed to optimize logistics and decision-making at scale are now generating kill lists, erasing families, and leveling entire neighborhoods.

This piece first appeared on 25 October 2025 in Al-Shabaka (The Palestinian Policy Network), and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

"The Days of the United States Propping Up the Entire World Order Like Atlas Are Over."

Trump's National Security Strategy document was released late on Thursday

Gary Olson

On Thursday, the White House released the new National Security Strategy for the United States. Others may well give it a different read, but here is my quick take: the document is ghoulish, abhorrent, repetitious, and sometimes incoherent, but I found its honesty refreshing. The mask is torn off sanctimonious bullshit, tall tales about spreading democracy and caring about human rights. The US is “not grounded in traditional political idealism,” but by “America First.” A bit of the usual boilerplate is here, but for the most part, the ideological cover is gone.

In place of pretense, the document spells out what US policy has always been about: undisguised economic nationalism — whatever benefits American grifter capitalism.

The Loneliness of Being Iranian in the Diaspora

Elaheh Farmand

My *Mamanbozorg* (maternal grandmother) died on Monday, January 5th, 2026, in Iran.

My family and I hadn't seen her in roughly four years. We didn't get to care for her or help her adjust to life in a nursing home. We didn't witness her dementia firsthand. We said our goodbyes from afar. We watched her burial through video footage and photos. We grieved as a family on FaceTime.

This is not unusual for Iranian families outside of Iran, who don't feel safe returning to their birth country, not even during times of grief. The Iranian government is unpredictable. They may be held on false espionage charges.

This is a layer of grief of being an immigrant that no one really talks about. To be an immigrant, especially one in exile, is to grieve not just the loss of a homeland but also the loss of loved ones. Some believe that seeing the body after death helps the living with the grief process. What about the immigrant mother who doesn't get to hold her dying mother's hand on her deathbed?

As I write this, Iran is once again in the headlines. Mainstream headlines are calling out the number of protester deaths. A hypocritical media is the perfect match for a hypocritical government. They assume the position of caring for the Iranian people and their human rights. When it comes to Iran, democracy and freedom matter to American media and politicians. Meanwhile, they have no problem with the slaughter of Palestinians. Palestinians' freedom and democracy are never considered.

Everyone on the Internet has an opinion on Iran. Leftists, conservatives, monarchists, liberals, Zionists: a collision of beliefs

about what's right for the future of Iranians and Iran.

I was born and raised in Iran and lived there for 11 years. I moved to the U.S. in 1999. My family has suffered unimaginable grief and cruelty under both governments: the Pahlavi Kingdom and the current Islamic Republic. No version of the Iranian flag resonates with me. I can sit here on my comfortable couch in suburban America and write about my dreams and visions for the Iranian people.

Instead, I sit with the reality that I have no idea what Iranians really want. I don't know what they go through day to day. I haven't been on the ground. I haven't spoken to them. I have a general sense from reports from friends, family, and the diaspora, but I don't know. I don't have the right to pretend that I do. I don't have the right to dictate to my Western audience that I am writing on behalf of all Iranian people.

I write from the position of being an Iranian immigrant woman in my late 30s, grieving the loss of my beloved *Mamanbozorg*, calling my mother daily to hold her grief and to fill the gaping hole in her heart with love. I am heartbroken to see Iranians dying on the streets, their voices yet again repressed. I am angry at Western politicians who pretend to care about Iranian life for their own interests and agendas in the region. I am angry at the Iranian government, which continues to kill, repress, and quash dissent. It feels isolating to want to speak on this grief but knowing that I must do so carefully or my words will be taken out of context.

Iranians, like any other people, deserve full human rights. They deserve dignity and freedom, and the right to choose their government. What they don't need is a Western savior.

Venezuela: It's Much More Than Oil

Don Fitz

As the US openly discussed schemes to add Greenland to its list of conquered territories, it became abundantly clear that “Alternative Energy” — solar, wind, and hydro power — joined fossil fuels at center stage. Corporations that pull the puppet strings of governments are well aware that oil production will cease long before none remains in the ground.

Solar panels, wind turbines, and hydro-dams are heavily dependent on oil to manufacture machinery, operate equipment and dispose of used products. Thus, oil and alternative energy are not separate; they are both sketches in the bigger picture of energy production. Greenland is closer to Venezuela than they appear on a map.

It may seem strange that rich world media focuses on Greenland and ignores what has already been done so extensively to the poor world. Actually, it is not strange at all. Explanation only requires one word which the rich world is loath to apply to itself: Racism. Or maybe another word or two: “Imperialism” and “Colonialism.”

This piece first appeared on 6 January 2026 in Green Social Thought, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

The Environmental Crisis Is a Capitalist Crisis

Tricontinental: Institute for Social Research

The photographs in the print edition of this dossier were taken by Sebastião Salgado, one of Brazil's — and the world's — greatest photographers. He passed away in May 2025, leaving behind an artistic legacy inseparable from his commitment to humanity and the preservation of the environment. Salgado travelled the globe portraying peoples, territories, and workers with dignity, capturing life's beauty while bearing witness to an era marked by capitalism's brutality against humanity and nature. His photographs, like this dossier, remind us that we cannot remain mere spectators of destruction: we must be agents of change. We are grateful to the team that safeguards his legacy and, in a spirit of solidarity, authorised the use of his images.

Capitalism Will Not Solve the Environmental Crisis

The environmental crisis is one of the greatest challenges we face today. At its root lie the capitalist mode of production and the logic of capital accumulation pursued by the ruling classes of the Global North and South. The devastation wrought by capitalism is plain for all to see, as climate change intensifies and accelerates year after year, threatening the very existence of humanity. As Fidel Castro warned in his speech at the 1992 UN Conference on Environment and Development in Rio de Janeiro, 'An important biological species is in danger of disappearing due to the rapid and progressive liquidation of its natural living conditions: humanity'.¹

Many international organisations and bodies have sought solutions to the environmental crisis, but always within the framework of capitalism. In November 2025, the United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP30) was held in Belém, Pará, in the Amazon region of Brazil. The Amazon is home to countless generations of Indigenous peoples who, through their interaction with nature, have allowed the planet's most biodiverse ecosystem to flourish.

Today, the Amazon is the site of one of capitalism's central contradictions: agribusiness destroys it by burning and clearing land to expand the agricultural frontier while the very same land is financialised by transnational corporations trading its territories as carbon reserves on stock exchanges. While the ruling classes insist on presenting the environmental crisis as a problem for all of humanity — without any class distinctions — we must not forget that the class contradictions inherent to capitalism are also reflected in the environmental question. In fact, those most affected by climate disasters are the urban and rural poor, who live under precarious conditions in hazard-prone areas.

One of the main tasks in the battle of ideas is therefore to politicise the debate around the environmental crisis by showing its class character — something that is urgently needed, as reflected by a recent survey that found that more than 30% of Brazil's population is unaware of climate change, with this figure rising to over 50% among the lowest income groups.²

The Destruction of Life and the Logic of Capital

Climate change is the most visible and urgent aspect of the environmental crisis. Chemical pollution, loss of soil cover, ocean acidification, biome destruction, and the loss of biodiversity are also fundamental dimensions of the crisis. As Vijay Prashad rightly pointed out: one million of the estimated eight million species of plants and animals on the planet are threatened with extinction.

The main threat to the majority of species at risk of extinction is biodiversity loss caused by the capitalist agribusiness system of food production. Agricultural production — currently accounting for more than 30% of the world's habitable land surface — is responsible for 86% of projected losses in terrestrial biodiversity because of land conversion, pollution, and soil degradation.³

The environmental crisis manifests in ways that underscore its inseparability from the class struggle. We see this in the floods that devastated southern Brazil in 2024; the heatwave and then floods that hit Pakistan in 2022, leaving millions homeless while elites remained protected; the 2018 floods in Kerala, India; the 2022 flooding and blackouts in Cuba caused by Hurricane Ian — a phenomenon intensified by rising ocean temperatures; and the increasingly extreme cycles of floods and droughts in the Horn of Africa. From 2019 to 2020, Ethiopia, Kenya, and Somalia faced heavy rains followed by devastating floods. From 2020 to 2023, these countries faced one of the longest droughts in the past seventy years, only to be hit by new floods in 2023–2024.

The main factor driving climate change is the high level of greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from fossil fuels as energy consumption from these fuels continues to rise year after year. If we take a closer look at global emission levels, the data once again speaks volumes: the richest 10% are responsible for nearly twenty times more emissions than the poorest 50%.⁴ Moreover, both historic and current GHG emissions are directly linked to inequality — not only between the Global North and South but also between the richest and poorest segments of the global population. According to the Global Carbon Project, the twenty-three most developed countries account for half of all CO₂ emissions since 1850. The United States alone has emitted 24.6% of all carbon released into the atmosphere, followed by Germany (5.5%), the United Kingdom (4.4%), and Japan (3.9%). The other half of emissions is spread across more than 150 countries.⁵

Recent data shows that this reality has not changed: according to a 2022 study by Climate Watch, the ten largest emitters are still responsible for 76% of global CO₂ emissions. In 2022, China was the largest emitter of CO₂, followed by the United States, India, Russia, and Japan, which would make Asia the planet's biggest emitter today. However, because the populations of countries such as China and India are much larger than those of the United States, European countries, Japan, or Australia, measured in per capita emissions the United States is by far the world's largest CO₂ emitter, with a per capita rate twice that of China and eight times higher than India's.

Globally, the fossil fuel industry is the largest emitter of CO₂, with roughly one hundred companies responsible for 71% of global historical CO₂ emissions, according to a Carbon Majors report published in 2017.⁶ Among them are giants such as ExxonMobil, Shell, BHP Billiton, and Gazprom. Another 2019 study by the Climate Accountability Institute found that just twenty companies have been responsible for one-third of all global CO₂ emissions since 1965.

Agribusiness is another structural driver of GHG emissions. In 2023 alone, 3.7 million hectares of forest were cleared worldwide, largely for cattle ranching and industrial crops. Over the past twenty years, the sector's production chain — from fertilisers to processing and transport — has increased its emissions by 130%. Though the energy sector accounts for approximately three-quarters of GHG emissions on a global scale, it is worth taking a closer look at countries where raw materials dominate exports. Brazil is a striking example: according to the *Plan for Ecological Transformation* published by the Ministry of Finance, agribusiness is the country's largest source of GHG emissions, directly accounting for 29% of the total. Deforestation-related emissions add another 38%, with livestock and agriculture responsible for about 96% of deforested land. Taken together, agribusiness is responsible for

roughly 67% of Brazil's total GHG emissions, compared to just 23% from energy generation.⁷

Despite regional and national differences, what is clear is that climate change and the destruction of nature are direct consequences of the logic of capital accumulation advanced by the ruling classes.

Green Capitalism: Supposed Alternatives to the Environmental Crisis

Various socialist currents have raised ecological concerns since the early days of capitalism, from the nineteenth-century socialist and artist William Morris to the environmental and countercultural movements of the mid-twentieth century. Yet it was only in the 1970s, more than a century after the first industries appeared, that the environment became a matter of concern for nation-states and began to gain prominence on the international political agenda. The 1972 United Nations Conference on the Human Environment, held in Stockholm, was a milestone in advancing the environmental question.

Despite the urgency of the environmental question, no new forms of organising production or relating to nature were proposed at the conference: rather, all alternatives fit within the capitalist mode of production. In 1979, the First World Climate Conference in Geneva acknowledged the seriousness of ongoing climate change. It was not until 1992 that the Second United Nations Conference on Environment and Development took place in Rio de Janeiro, where a multilateral agenda to address the climate question was proposed. This agenda entered into force in 1994 and served as the precursor to the Conference of the Parties (COP).

Among the many outcomes of the COP process, two stand out. First, the Kyoto Protocol, adopted after COP 3 in 1997, which set binding quantitative targets for reducing GHG emissions for Annex

I countries. Second, the Paris Agreement, adopted after COP 21 in 2015, which required signatory countries to set their own emission reduction targets. However, the targets were never met and both the Kyoto and Paris agreements ended up as failures.

In response to the urgency of climate change, some states have promoted a transition to a low-carbon economy aimed at reducing the amount of harmful GHG emissions — without, of course, touching the profits of major corporations and the capitalist core. From this approach emerged so-called ‘green capitalism’ alternatives, including carbon markets, offset schemes, and energy transition policies.

The Kyoto Protocol emission targets, initially intended to curb air pollution, soon became the basis for a new form of capital accumulation via so-called carbon credits that are traded on stock exchanges and function as a kind of ‘license to pollute’. Once companies exceed their GHG emission limits, they can buy carbon credits on the stock exchange to offset their emissions. Thus, the biophysical process by which plants absorb carbon from the air and convert it to oxygen through photosynthesis — a natural function of plant life and part of the commons — is turned into a commodity.

The main contradiction of green capitalism is that the same agribusiness, oil, and mining transnational corporations that shape the environmental agenda in international bodies and national governments are also those that most aggressively exploit the commons. The agribusiness sector, which drives deforestation and burning in the Cerrado and Amazon biomes in order to expand the agricultural frontier, also touts the digitalisation of its production chains, which certify that its products are deforestation-free and decarbonised. Similarly, oil corporations are involved in energy transition policies, and mining companies promote carbon market schemes.

Take, for example, the Maísa project in the Brazilian state of Pará, run by the leading carbon market certifier Verra. The project was meant to preserve a 26,000-hectare stretch of the Amazon rain-

forest that included the Sipasa Farm, yet the designated protection area later became a mining site, and in early 2024 sixteen farm workers were rescued from conditions comparable to slavery. The fallacy — and failure — of such projects is clear: they serve transnational giants like iFood, Uber, Spotify, Audi, and Google, which pour millions of dollars into offset schemes to cover the emissions generated by their own activities.⁸

One thing is clear: there are no capitalist solutions to a crisis created by capitalism. If we are to save the Earth and humanity, the answers must come from beyond capitalism.

Popular Perspectives on the Environmental Question

At the 1992 UN Conference in Rio de Janeiro, Fidel Castro underscored the urgency of the environmental crisis from an emancipatory perspective:

It must be said that consumer societies are primarily responsible for the atrocious destruction of the environment... With only 20% of the world's population, they consume two-thirds of the metals and three-quarters of the energy produced worldwide... It is impossible to blame this on the countries of the Third World — yesterday's colonies, today's exploited and plundered nations by an unjust world economic order... If we are to save humanity from this self-destruction, we must achieve a fairer distribution of the wealth and technology available on the planet — less luxury and less waste in a few countries so that there may be less poverty and less hunger across much of the Earth.

The struggle for climate justice must combat not only inequality between the Global North and South but also environmental racism, as it is the poorest, and disproportionately Black and Brown, populations in the Global South that are the most exposed to the effects of the environmental crisis. In Brazil, for example, a study found traces of glyphosate — one of the most widely used

pesticides in agribusiness — in breast milk across several regions. Meanwhile, the environmental crimes committed by the mining transnationals Samarco, Vale, and BHP Billiton in the cities of Mariana (2015) and Brumadinho (2019) not only killed nearly 300 people but also devastated the biodiversity of the Doce River, disrupting the way of life of numerous *comunidades ribeirinhas* (river communities).

Among the many fronts of struggle, peasant movements linked to La Vía Campesina stand out. Their agenda calls for **Popular Agrarian Reform and the Defence of Peasant and Indigenous Territories**, which challenges the agribusiness model that commodifies nature; **Food Sovereignty**, the right of peoples to decide what to produce, for whom, and how; **Agroecology**, a radical change in the technological model of agriculture; and **Care for the Commons**, on the understanding that water, minerals, seeds, land, and biodiversity are not ‘natural resources’ to be exploited but commons essential to life.

As MST leader João Pedro Stédile said about the particular challenges Brazil faces — though his words apply to the Global South more broadly:

We need zero deforestation. There is no need to cut down a single tree to meet the people’s needs. We must ban the export of timber and gold and impose strict controls over mining activities and their environmental impacts. The country needs a publicly funded national reforestation plan to recover millions of hectares throughout the territory. To tackle pollution, mitigate rising temperatures, and confront the problem of individual transportation powered by fossil fuels, we must provide a plan for free, high-quality mass public transport, reforest major cities, and expand the use of solar energy in as many productive activities as possible. In the countryside, agrarian reform must advance with a national agroecology programme that produces healthy food free of agrottoxins for all the people.

Another perspective that has emerged from social struggles in Latin America, especially in Ecuador and Bolivia, is *buen vivir*

(good living), whose principles were incorporated into the new constitutions of both countries. Drawing on Indigenous traditions, *buen vivir* challenges capitalist notions of progress and is based on five principles: a holistic vision, or *Pacha*; embracing multipolarity; the search for balance; the complementarity of diversity; and decolonisation.

Ecosocialism, for its part, is a political and theoretical current that combines socialism with radical ecology, criticising both capitalism and traditional socialism for ignoring the planet's ecological limits. For Michael Löwy, one of ecosocialism's leading theorists, the central dilemma facing the working classes in the twenty-first century is the environmental crisis, which must be addressed from a socialist perspective that conceives of a new mode of production attuned to ecological challenges.

The environmental crisis will not be resolved by the ruling classes. This is the task of the rural and urban working classes.

A Minimum Agenda to Confront the Environmental Crisis

Brazil's popular movements understand the need to wage struggles on multiple fronts. Despite the limits of the COPs, popular movements recognise that it is essential to pressure their governments to secure a minimum agenda that holds the social classes and countries most responsible for pollution accountable. Working alongside the MST, we created the following agenda.

I. COMPLIANCE WITH AND ADVANCEMENT OF INTERNATIONAL AGREEMENTS

- Building on the 1992 principle of 'common but differentiated responsibilities', compel Global North countries to rapidly cut their carbon emissions and prevent global temperatures from rising above the critical 1.5°C threshold.

- Ensure that Global North countries provide climate compensation to Global South countries for the losses and damages caused by their carbon emissions.
- Fulfil the Paris Agreement pledge of \$100 billion annually, delivered as grants directly transferred to subnational projects – not loans, and not pretexts for financial sector profit.
- Transfer technology and financing to Global South countries to phase out carbon-based energy systems.
- Hold Global North countries accountable for polluting water, soil, and air with toxic and hazardous waste, including nuclear waste.

II. A PLANNED AND JUST ENERGY TRANSITION WITH SOCIAL PARTICIPATION

- End direct and indirect government subsidies for the fossil fuel industry.
- Aggressively increase taxes on emissions and polluting products.
- Prohibit the financial sector's participation in the fossil fuel industry, to prevent any transition being driven by financial speculation.
- Direct state investment to combat the climate catastrophe, protect affected populations, and restore the environment, guaranteed against austerity.

III. PROTECTION OF AND SUPPORT FOR PEASANT AGRICULTURE AND FOOD SOVEREIGNTY

- Implement comprehensive agrarian reforms that decentralise and democratise access to land.
- Provide technical assistance and financing to spread agroecology.

- Eliminate synthetic agROTOXINS by 2035 and halve synthetic fertilisers in the same period.
- Support bio-inputs by creating bio-factories, with equipment and free technical assistance.
- Protect peasants' rights to biodiverse seeds and guarantee the intellectual property rights of Indigenous and traditional communities against biopiracy.
- Restructure livestock farming so that herd sizes correspond to land capacity and food demand, not market demand.
- Ban all unproven agricultural technologies and eliminate public subsidies for harmful practices.
- Establish legislation protecting agroecological zones free from poisons, GMOs, and aerial spraying.

IV. EFFECTIVE POLICIES FOR REFORESTATION AND COMBATTING DEFORESTATION

- Protect 80% of the Amazon's territory by 2026 to prevent it reaching its point of no return.
- Halt all illegal deforestation by 2026; achieve zero legal deforestation by 2027.
- Sanction those responsible for land grabbing and displacing forest-dwelling peoples.
- Prohibit Paris Agreement funds from being channelled to agribusiness, mining, or false solutions like offset schemes in protected areas.
- Title all Indigenous, Afro-descendant, quilombola and traditional lands, with full legal and physical protection.
- Classify ecocide as a crime in national legislation.
- Prosecute corporations responsible for environmental disasters in their countries of origin.

- Ban forest offsets and other forms of financial speculation in these territories.

V. PROPER PLANNING AND MANAGEMENT OF WATER RESOURCES

- Use water efficiently, prioritising human and animal consumption and agroecological production over corporate interests.
- Create protected areas that safeguard the health of river basins.
- Subsidise agroforestry, with an emphasis on food production in family farming units.

VI. RESTRICTIONS ON MINING

- Immediately halt and combat illegal mining.
- Reduce mercury use each year until it is fully eliminated.
- Ban mining in Indigenous, ancestral, and communal territories.
- Establish plans to restore areas degraded by mining, and remediation plans for affected ecosystems and communities.
- Create monitoring systems and penalties for activities that compromise surface and groundwater quality.

VII. PUBLIC PARTICIPATION

- Ensure that the population — especially forest-dwelling peoples and those disproportionately affected by climate change — has a voice, a vote, and veto power in decision-making, oversight, and resource use in projects affecting their territories.
- Require institutional bodies introducing new technologies in rural areas to let affected populations intervene both before and during commercial authorisation.

FOOTNOTES

1. Fidel Castro, speech to the UN Conference on Environment and Development, Rio de Janeiro, 12 June 1992. ↩
2. Instituto de Pesquisas, survey on climate awareness in Brazil, cited in the original dossier. ↩
3. Vijay Prashad, on biodiversity loss and the capitalist agribusiness system of food production. ↩
4. On the emissions gap between the richest 10% and the poorest 50% of the world's population. ↩
5. Global Carbon Project, cumulative CO₂ emissions since 1850. ↩
6. *Carbon Majors Report* (2017); Climate Accountability Institute (2019). ↩
7. Ministry of Finance, *Plan for Ecological Transformation; 2022 Annual Deforestation Report*. ↩
8. On the Maísa project in Pará and the Verra certification scheme. ↩

This piece first appeared on 13 October 2025 in Tricontinental: Institute for Social Research, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

Trump: Sincerity and Verisimilitude

Kim Petersen

US president Donald Trump is apparently trying to burnish his Christian bona fides on Truth Social, threatening to go into Nigeria “guns-a-blazing” to completely wipe out the Islamic Terrorists he holds responsible for the killing of Christians. Secretary of War Pete Hegseth saluted his commander-in-chief: “Yes sir.”

First off, any comments made by Trump and his yes-men and yes-women ought to be greeted with utmost skepticism. And the aphorism of “Fool me once, shame on you; fool me twice, shame on me” ought to be rigorously applied.

For instance, if Trump is so concerned about the plight of Christians in Nigeria, then where was this concern for the Christian segment of Palestinians killed by Israeli forces?

Ask: what ties all these examples together? Oil.

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Doomed, Not Domed?

The Wrath of the Con Man

Ashley Gate and William D. Hartung

Kathryn Bigelow's new nuclear thriller, *A House of Dynamite*, has been criticized by some experts for being unrealistic, most notably because it portrays an unlikely scenario in which an adversary chooses to attack the United States with just a single nuclear-armed missile. But the film is strikingly on target when it comes to one thing: its portrayal of the way one U.S. missile interceptor after another misses its target, despite the confidence of most American war planners that they would be able to destroy any incoming nuclear warhead and save the day.

In fact, the situation is far worse than that. We taxpayers, whether we know it or not, are betting on a house of dynamite, gambling on the idea that technology will save us in the event of a nuclear attack. The United States has spent more than \$350 billion on missile defenses since, more than four decades ago, President Ronald Reagan promised to create a leak-proof defense against incoming intercontinental ballistic missiles. Believe it or not, the Pentagon has yet to even conduct a realistic test of the system.

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The People of Ecuador Reject the Return of US Military Bases

Progressive International Observatory

In a national referendum, more than 60% of Ecuadorians roundly opposed proposals to lift a longstanding ban on foreign bases and make significant changes to the revolutionary 2008 Constitution of Montecristi. The significance of this victory cannot be understated.

As the Trump Administration looks to reassert the Monroe Doctrine in Latin America, Ecuador's rejection effectively blocks the US military from returning to the Manta airbase — closed in 2009 in accordance with the constitutional mandate — on the Pacific coast, once a hub for Washington's anti-drug operations.

Yet, just as the USS Gerald R Ford — the world's largest and most expensive aircraft carrier — reached the Caribbean coast, the people of Ecuador struck a blow against imperial expansion.

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Sorry, White Nationalists

Juan R. I. Cole

We live in a time when a once level-headed anti-populist politician such as JD Vance has increasingly adopted the language of white nationalism, signing on to the Great Replacement theory that nefarious forces, often coded as Jewish, are bringing in immigrants to replace “white” Americans, attacking “multiculturalism” and aligning himself with Christian theocratic nationalism. That his wife, Usha, is from India is inconvenient to this shift, of course. The shameful Great Replacement theory now embraced by Vance was invented by a French Nazi who considered all Americans “Negroes.”

Whiteness is a term with a checkered history. As a historian, I would argue that it is an objectively meaningless construct. It is only meaningful, like any political identity, in a carefully crafted context and through various sleights of hand. I have pointed out that Benjamin Franklin only considered the English white, dismissing Swedes as “tawny” and Germans as “swarthy.” In the twentieth century, working-class Italians, Greeks, and Irish were gradually admitted to “whiteness,” which had, in the nineteenth century, been associated with Protestantism, middle- and upper-class status, and northern European origins. That is, whiteness in America was always mostly about class and religion and unfree antecedents rather than about skin color. Some African Americans have a lighter complexion than some Mediterranean populations. Arab Americans were admitted to whiteness in the early 20th century by the courts, though after September 11, their whiteness was often revoked.

That ICE has not gone after the thousands of undocumented Irish in the Boston area or other “white” undocumented immi-

grants, but only after those coded “brown” or “black,” demonstrates that Stephen Miller’s project is a racist one, not purely about immigration or undocumented immigration.

One of the symbols of whiteness for Americans constructing a white identity is Europeaness, especially northern Europeaness. It should be remembered that Adolf Hitler initially rebuffed Benito Mussolini’s offer of an alliance because he did not consider Italians white, and kept hoping that instead he could conclude an alliance with Britain.

The bad news for white nationalism is that Europe’s genetic history has revealed that Europeans were mostly dark-skinned until the first millennium BC, and even then, whiteness advanced slowly. This belatedness of light complexions has been demonstrated by a scientific paper just this year.¹ Joseph Shavit summarizes the paper of Professor Perretti and colleagues: “Researchers at the University of Ferrara in Italy studied the genomes of 348 people who lived between 45,000 and 1,700 years ago across Europe and western Asia. Their findings show that about 63% of ancient Europeans had dark skin. Only about 8% had pale skin. The rest had tones in between.”

In fact, Ötzi the Iceman, from circa 3000 BC, is both one of Europe’s oldest preserved mummies and one of the darkest Europeans known. Reconstructions of him have made him look white, which is just ideology, not science.

Modern Europeans are immigrants, since much of Europe was not inhabited during the last Ice Age, the glacial maximum of which lasted from roughly 29,000 to 11,700 years ago. After that, Africans and people from what we now term the Middle East came in to repopulate the continent.

They were black? They were black. They came from places closer to the equator, where UV rays were strong and dark pigmentation blocked them, reducing the danger of genetic damage to embryos.

The major natural selection mechanism for light skin is that in northern climes UV rays are weak and dark pigmentation blocks their absorption. UV rays provoke humans to produce vitamin D. Lack of vitamin D is associated with a range of poor health outcomes, including increased risk of osteoporosis and “common cancers, autoimmune diseases, hypertension, and infectious diseases.” It is also associated with multiple sclerosis and dementia.

The most important point here is that a lack of vitamin D harms fetal and maternal health.

So, in Sub-Saharan Africa, if two women were pregnant and one was slightly darker than the other, her embryo would have a very slightly better chance of being protected from harsh UV rays and of being healthy and would be selected for.

Take the same two women to Sweden, and the shoe is on the other foot. The slightly lighter woman’s embryo would have a better chance of getting sufficient vitamin D by being exposed to the weak UV rays up there, and her child would be selected for. Thousands of years later, her descendants would be white as snow.

So modern Europeans are just Africans and Middle Easterners (and some Eurasians) who, over time, lightened in response to weak ultraviolet radiation through natural selection.

It wasn’t until the era of the foundation of Rome, however, that any significant number of Europeans began being lighter-complexioned.

As Dario Radley concludes in *Archaeology News*, dark skin was replaced much more slowly in Europe than had been earlier thought. Why? It turns out that *diet* is also important. European hunters and gatherers ate foods such as meat, fish, and wild plants that were relatively high in vitamin D, enabling them to survive even at northern latitudes with weak UV rays while retaining dark complexions.

The Neolithic agricultural revolution, in which people from what is now Türkiye gradually expanded into Europe and brought grain agriculture, introduced a diet relatively poor in vitamin D. So

European farmers were subject to natural selection, which favored lighter skin. Some of the farmers who came in from the Middle East were from families that had already lightened up because of this diet change.

So, white Europeans in the sense of light-complected ones, are a recent historical phenomenon. And of course, in southern Europe, people are generally darker. But the point is that all human beings are descended from people we would now code as black.

I don't know what glory there is in being light-skinned descendants of black people because of resettling in northern climes with weak UV rays. At the least, exulting in whiteness in this sense would mean demeaning your own ancestors and family line. All those Americans who think of Rome several times a day should be aware that Romulus and Remus, the mythical figures whose story is intertwined with the founding of Rome, couldn't have been served in a restaurant in the American South in the 1950s.

That is not to mention that the Roman Empire was both among the greatest empires in history and the most multicultural. At its height, it ruled from Morocco to the Caucasus and from Spain to what is now Türkiye. It included Arabophone peoples, Aramaic speakers, Grecophone populations, Anatolian speakers of Iranian languages, Basques, Goths, Celts, and Etruscans, as well as Romans. When the Romans conquered Syria, they admitted its elites to their aristocracy and had as emperors Philip the Arab (r. 244-249 AD, born in Auranitis, Syria), as well as Elagabalus and Severus Alexander, both from the Emesene dynasty from Homs in Syria, as well as Caracalla, whose mother was from the Syrian Arab family of the Severans.

Elagabalus (r. 218-222) in Arabic is *ilah al-jabal*, the god of the mountain. *Ilah* is the Arabic word for "a god," with the definite being *al-Ilah* or, in Jordan and the Hejaz, *Allah*. So Westerners who don't like hearing the term Allah can't even reckon with their own Roman legacy. As for Vance's diss on multiculturalism, it doesn't

make it easy to understand the greatness of the great multicultural empires, not least Rome itself.

Whiteness and Westernness are such fragile ideas that they break down rapidly when subjected to the historian's gaze. They are a fragile reed on which to base the politics of 350 million diverse Americans, all of them ultimately descended from black people.

FOOTNOTES

1. S. Perretti et al., "Inference of human pigmentation from ancient DNA by genotype likelihoods," *Proc. Natl. Acad. Sci. U.S.A.* 122 (29) e2502158122 (2025). <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2502158122> (<https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2502158122>) ↩

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The Proof is in the Pudding: A Few Comments on Socialism with Chinese Characteristics

Gary Olson

The Communist Party of China was founded in Shanghai in July 1921. At its inception the CPC had only 50 members — 100 million today — and came to power in 1949 after 28 years of revolutionary struggle.

The ideal of “Common Prosperity” had its origins in the CPC’s founding and was made official policy in December 1953 in a report drafted by Mao Zedong. It is important to clarify that the term envisioned an egalitarian, mutual aid type society in which resources would be held in common.

China incorporated market mechanisms, but they operate under the socialist state, which is controlled by the CPC, not private capitalists as is the case in the United States. Yes, millionaires and billionaires exist in China — some are even party members — but the CPC does not allow them to constitute a capitalist class. They’re prevented from establishing their own political parties or organizing their own media.

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Let the Sudanese People Walk Toward Peace

Vijay Prashad

In early November, United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres addressed the “horrific crisis in Sudan, which is spiralling out of control”. He urged the warring parties to “bring an end to this nightmare of violence — now”. There is a path to end the war, but there is simply no political will to enforce it.

On 15 April 2023, war broke out between the Sudanese Armed Forces, led by General Abdel Fattah al-Burhan, and the Rapid Support Forces, led by Lieutenant General Mohamed ‘Hemedti’ Hamdan Dagalo. Since then, backed by various governments from outside of Sudan, the two sides have fought a terrible war of attrition in which civilians are the main victims.

No war of this scale has one simple cause. The political reason is straightforward: this is a counter-revolution against the 2019 popular uprising that succeeded in ousting President Omar al-Bashir.

To the people of El Fasher, to those in Khartoum, to my comrades in Port Sudan: walk toward peace.

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AI's Grand Circus

We inflate markets, deflate possibility, and call it progress.

Democracy At Work

“They knew. They knew the taxpayers would bail them out. They weren’t being stupid; they just didn’t care.” — *The Big Short* (2015)

There is a scene in *The Big Short* that still feels like prophecy. As the housing market collapses, a banker turns to the camera and admits that the whole thing was built on faith — faith that the numbers meant something, faith that the system couldn’t fail because it never had. It was a con of belief, not math.

That same fever — first mortgages, then modems — now burns beneath the rhetoric of artificial intelligence. The same hunger that once promised homes for all — and later, connection for all — now promises intelligence for all. Every era sells its miracle: the mortgage, the modem, the model. And each time, we are told that this one will redeem the last. Strip away the language and reality begins to melt — speculation takes the shape of salvation; hype hardens into strategy. Once, Wall Street packaged our homes; now, Silicon Valley packages our intelligence. Both sell the same illusion — that if we just believe hard enough, the system consuming us will somehow set us free.

There is a strange miracle in what we call the market. Every dollar, every share, every speculative bet represents something vast and human: our collective labor, our choices, our potential. The money that moves through Wall Street and venture funds is not abstract; it is the summation of our past labor and the collateralization of our future. It is our time, our creativity, our hopes — rendered tradable, then molded by those with the wealth to decide their worth.

When capital chases “intelligence,” it practices a new kind of alchemy: transmuting human thought into speculative gold. Each model is trained on our collective past — our voices, our labor, our words — and returns as something that claims to surpass us. The miracle, we’re told, is that machines can think. The truth is simpler and stranger: they only think because we already did.

We hear from Democrats and Republicans alike that the problem is greed — a moral failing, they say, rather than a structural design. But what system have we built other than one that glorifies it? The billions pouring into AI are not “new money”; they are the residue of our collective labor, recycled into a machine that promises efficiency while eroding the meaning of work itself. Something of value will emerge from this frenzy — just as the dot-com bubble left behind the infrastructure of the modern web — but we should be honest about what these manias are. They are moral decisions disguised as market logic: our shared labor repackaged as profit, our common future traded for someone’s gain.

And yet, without this latest speculative boom, our economy might already be in recession. The market’s vitality depends on its next story, its next frontier — and so we inflate another balloon. In 2024 alone, private U.S. investment in artificial intelligence reached roughly \$109 billion, according to Stanford’s AI Index Report 2025, and major firms are now committing hundreds of billions more to AI infrastructure and data centers in 2025.

For comparison, researchers estimate that ending homelessness nationwide would cost on the order of \$9–30 billion a year; clearing the public-transit repair backlog would require about \$140 billion; and cancelling student debt for millions of Americans could cost anywhere from \$300 billion (for a \$10,000 per-borrower plan) to over \$870 billion. These are not impossible sums; they are simply directed elsewhere.

The problem is not that we invest in technology — it’s that we do so to avoid investing in one another. We could rebuild public transit, deliver universal healthcare, cancel student debt, end home-

lessness — all projects of collective possibility — but instead we feed the circus. We reward those who promise salvation through algorithms while punishing those who simply demand dignity through policy. And if AI spend is today's growth engine, it is also today's concentration risk — a stimulus routed through a handful of firms, data centers, and supply chains.

The defenders of this frenzy will tell us to look forward — to think of the productivity gains that will surely justify today's excess. It is, they insist, shortsighted to critique the future before it arrives. But history is not a ledger that balances itself. Productivity gains are not moral gains; they are distributed, like everything else, according to power. The Industrial Revolution doubled output but also deepened inequality. The internet democratized information, yet concentrated ownership. Efficiency rose; bargaining power fell.

None of this means progress is futile. Real advances will come from AI — in medicine, in research, in the dull work of bureaucracy. But we should not mistake *output* for *outcome*. The measure of progress is not how quickly we can produce, but how fully we can live. Productivity is only liberation when it frees time for care, creativity, and collective flourishing. Otherwise, it is just acceleration — movement without direction, growth without meaning.

Beneath the tent, the showman smiles and tells us we're having fun — that the chaos is part of the magic. But behind the applause, a quieter feeling lingers: this isn't wonder; it's surrender.

I am no Luddite. I believe deeply in using technology to make our lives better — to shorten the distance between people, to relieve us from drudgery, to open time for meaning and care. But that's not what this is. What Silicon Valley calls "progress" is often a reshuffling of burdens — a promise of liberation whose costs are borne by everyone but the liberated. AI is not inherently the enemy. The enemy is our inability, or unwillingness, to direct its fruits toward the collective good. It is not the code that corrupts, but the context that consumes it.

Assemblyman Zohran Mamdani captured this tension perfectly when he told a crowd in New York:

We have been told that change is not yet quite possible, that it's not yet our turn... My friends, we are not afforded the luxury of waiting, because too often to wait is to trust those who delivered us to this point.

What Mamdani calls for is more than political imagination — it is a politics of refusal, of faith made action, of people reclaiming the power to decide what the future is for. The ruling class has merely changed its costume. The bankers became venture capitalists; the venture capitalists became visionaries. The same men who built temples to debt now build temples to data, learning that belief is more valuable than truth. Yesterday, they sold us the dream of universal ownership; today, the dream of universal intelligence. Each collapse births a new faith; each failure is repackaged as the next frontier. They call it innovation. We call it *déjà vu*.

But faith is not imagination — it is surrender disguised as hope. The question before us is not whether AI will “change everything,” but whether we will allow the same forces that profited from the last collapse to define what change means. Capital always finds its next frontier: land, labor, data, currency, cognition. What it cannot reproduce is will — the collective will to direct progress toward the public good rather than private gain.

For all the talk of transcendence, today's machines are not thinking in any meaningful sense — they are pattern engines, fluent mimics trained to predict what sounds right, not what is true. They interpolate within the past but cannot imagine beyond it. What we call “intelligence” is mostly scale: more data, more parameters, more power drawn from the grid. The result is not cognition but compression — a mirror polished by our own reflections. Yet on this fragile scaffold of imitation, an entire economy of faith has been built, trading comprehension for confidence, and verification for valuation.

And what have these miracles yielded? A torrent of synthetic content and algorithmic noise — tools built less to enlighten than to extract, refining the art of persuasion into a quieter advertising, a subtler surveillance, mining not only what we see but what we think.

Once, technology was sold with the promise of leisure — shorter days, lighter work, freedom from drudgery. No one says that anymore. The language of emancipation has vanished, replaced by the rhetoric of disruption, regulation, and fear. We are told that artificial intelligence might end civilization or save it, depending on who controls the narrative. The result is the same: a politics of panic that consolidates power in the hands of those already trusted to manage risk.

The dot-com boom promised liberation through connection; the financial bubble promised security through ownership; the AI boom promises transcendence through intelligence. Each framed its miracle as inevitable. Each was built on the same moral deficit — the refusal to imagine a world where progress is measured not by valuation, but by how well it meets our common needs.

“Not everything that is faced can be changed, but nothing can be changed until it is faced.” — James Baldwin

The task, then, is not to resist technology but to reclaim possibility — to treat innovation not as spectacle but as stewardship. The resources exist; every crisis proves that when the will is found, the funds appear. The question is not how we will pay for it, but who it will serve.

In the end, every bubble bursts, every circus folds. What remains is the work — the unfinished labor of turning faith into will and will into the common good.

This piece first appeared on 21 October 2025 in Democracy At Work, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

Larry Summers, Epstein, and the "End Game" Memo

Greg Palast

Forgive me, but I have to send a little thank you to Jeffrey Epstein. The latest cache of the predator's memos has finally brought down Lawrence Summers, once President of Harvard University, once US Secretary of the Treasury and the dark eminence behind banking deregulation and mass home foreclosures. And worse.

But let's set aside Larry the Lecher. This is the moment to reveal how Summers has used his power not just to abuse women but to abuse the planet. His victims *number in the millions*. No kidding. Stay with me on this. We begin with the "end game."

In 2013, a little birdy dropped a highly confidential note written to Summers from his flunky, Timothy Geithner, then Assistant Secretary for International Affairs. Its content was so explosive, so sick and plain evil, I just could barely believe it. The scheme revealed in the note was breathtaking: complete deregulation of the *worldwide* banking system.

This piece first appeared on 23 November 2025 in Greg Palast Investigates, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

Mass Murder as "Public Service" in "Our Democracy"

Michael Smith

Super-hawk Elliott Abrams is back in the news again, worrying that Donald Trump lacks “clarity” about what he intends to do in Venezuela. Abrams recommends that the president eliminate all doubts and ambiguities in his mind and directly attack Venezuelan territory in order to bring down the “dictator” Nicolás Maduro.

Abrams nowhere takes note of the huge risks U.S. military escalation necessarily carries with it, namely, that it might provoke a Vietnam-style bloodbath or worse, after uniting all of Latin America against Washington’s unprovoked aggression.

Of course, all of this is only to be expected from Abrams, who is a former senior Middle East adviser on the National Security Council for George W. Bush, in which position he promoted the 2003 invasion of Iraq, and a disastrous coup against the democratically elected Hamas government in Gaza.

This piece first appeared on 25 November 2025 in Legalienate, and is reproduced here under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

Ms Maxwell and The Art of The Deal

Raymond Nat Turner

For her silence she wants the Ruby
Slippers back — along with her broomstick — The Lolita Express ...
Better yet ... she
Wants the jet Qatar gifted grifter Boss Tweet.

She wants all alphabet agencies who
Spy on the American People
Mobilized/weaponized to find out which
Hedge fund flipped a house on her sister.

She wants ICE rounding up a million Munchkins a month
For her pleasure. She wants scores of other peoples' babies.
She wants impunity to work Quinceañeras, Bat Mitzvahs,
Sweet Sixteens with former father figure, Jel-Low Puddin Man.

She wants a new psyop to co-opt left language.
She wants to use “What’s the call? Free ‘em all!”
To Free Harvey! Free Diddy! Free R. Kelly! And
Allow Russell Simmons to sing, “I believe I can fly!”

She wants Slick Willy notified that honeypots and
Sandwiches will return shortly. She wants Cuomo
To know he can come and go. She wants Papa Cop
To know that he can fly — free — to Turkey.

She wants baby oil tariffs removed. She wants
Diddy as mixologist aboard the Love Boat her
Father fell from and drowned in waters off the
Canary Islands.

She wants use of some 800 plus bases run by
Greasy-thumbed generals. Preferably, those
Named for confederate traitors. She wants to erect a new
Headquarters. A station. A secure location for predation.

She wants to “steal” reich-cult blondes for weekly workouts.
Smoothie-fueled saunas, steam baths and mani-pedis in secure
White supremacist, settler-colonial, tropical paradises. Built on
Profaned bones of indigenous ancestors.

Finally, if she’s found “unresponsive.” Entangled in sheets.
Tumbled from
10th floor window. Or, reciting autopsy, a coroner crows, “A little

poison!”

Bury her atop her triple-agent Pop. In Jerusalem’s Mount of Olives Cemetery.

With international intelligence community elite turnout — With
21 gun salute ...

Notes from the Editors

Ukrainian Draft Evasion

We know that Ukraine is running out of troops in a war of attrition and that Russia is making steady, inexorable advances on the battlefield. For weeks now I've been paying close attention to the situation in Pokrovsk, a strategic city in Western Donetsk. Reports from both sides indicate that thousands of Ukrainian soldiers in Pokrovsk are surrounded by 150,000 Russian troops. The British *Financial Times* and *Daily Telegraph* are reporting that Pokrovsk is about to fall, and this could trigger a total collapse of Ukraine's western Donetsk front line.

Given this reality, I was struck by the placement of a piece on Ukrainian draft dodgers on the front page of today's *New York Times*. Is this above-the-fold article, with six photos, a tacit admission by the editors that the US proxy war in Ukraine has been lost?

Many men of draft age, 20 to 60, have either fled the country or are in hiding. The article confirms that "criminal networks smuggle people out the country illegally for a steep price," even though the price is \$15,000 and being caught means a nine-year prison sentence.

As for the army itself, prosecutors have opened 290,000 cases for desertion or being absent without leave. The article points out that in Vylkove, a small town in southernmost Ukraine, half of the men of military age never leave their houses out of fear of being caught by draft officers and pressed into service. Women have taken on most of the jobs.

A Few Quotes About ICE

"ICE isn't just about immigration. It's about normalizing secret police in our society." — *Max Blumenthal*

"No One's Illegal On Stolen Land." — *Protest sign*

"ICE Melts Under Resistance." — *Protest sign*

“Trump did a better job. I don’t like Trump, you know, but we should have a secure border and it ain’t that hard to do. Biden didn’t do it.” — *Sen. Bernie Sanders, Tim Dillon Show*

“ICE Considering Paying Private Bounty Hunters to Track Immigrants.” — *Newsweek, November 9, 2025*

“The US economy runs on the backs of illegal immigrants.” — *Scott Ritter*

“The Trump administration is replacing nearly half of the top ICE field officers with current or retired Border Patrol officers. The Border Patrol has a culture of cruelty, racism, and impunity for human rights violations.” — *ACLU*

Chicago Alderman Mike Rodriguez on the Border Patrol’s “reign of terror” in his neighborhood: “Left unchecked their mandate will grow; the boundaries of acceptable identity and speech will shrink.”

I Bet You Didn't Know

On December 5, the UN adopted — with only TWO countries opposing — a resolution proclaiming December 14th as the International Day against Colonialism in All Its Forms and Manifestations, commemorating the 1960 Declaration on the Granting of Independence to Colonial Countries and Peoples.

Do you really need to guess which two countries opposed? The answer, for those whose heads are still in the sand: **USA & Israel.**

Growing Global Inequality

A just-released report finds that the top 0.001% of the world’s population own three times as much wealth as the poorest half of the world’s population combined. The share of the latter in all wealth is barely 2%, while the top 10% control nearly three-quarters of global wealth.

We haven't arrived at what's often called the "post-truth" condition with Trump and Trumpism only. For one, have you ever — and I mean given decades, not just the last few years — had any success convincing a pro-Israel person, be they Christian, Jewish, Muslim, or secular, politician or not, by recounting the undisputed facts on the ground in Palestine?

We want to remind the nearly half of Israelis who said recently that they will not visit New York City if Zohran Mamdani wins, to stick to their promise. We remind them that compromise is not an option for them given their undying commitment to Zionism and genocide, ethnic cleansing, and apartheid in Palestine. So, stay the f* out of New York City.

"On a Single Day in Monaco, 50% of the Bugattis and Ferraris Had Ukrainian Number Plates."

After spending time in Monaco with his girlfriend, Donald Trump Jr. made this comment at the recent Doha conference. Trump Jr. asked, "Do you think that was earned in Ukraine?" He continued by saying "The corrupt rich have all moved to Monaco, leaving the 'peasants' to continue fighting the war." Even leaving room for hyperbole, he's not wrong. He also volunteered that the US is no longer going to be the "idiot with the checkbook." In fact, the new Pentagon budget authorizes the "idiot" to give another \$400 million to Ukraine.

As the collapse of the proxy war draws closer, the political class in Kiev — the criminal grifters — are stealing everything that's not nailed down. A cynic would say that Zelensky needs to keep the money flowing to his supporters to remain in power and this will continue until Russia prevails and the ATM shuts down. At home, we know that the US could pull the plug on the war in a New York minute but the neocons, Deep State and the media remain adamantly opposed to any settlement. At least that's our overall sense of things.

***The Eyes of Gaza: A Diary of Resilience*, by Plestia Alaqad**

We recently had an opportunity to read *The Eyes of Gaza: A Diary of Resilience*, a recent book by 22-year-old Plestia Alaqad. Just before the genocide started she was a recent graduate with a degree in journalism, looking to start her career. When Israel launched its genocide in Gaza, she went from aspiring journalist to actual on-the-ground journalist.

Most recent writing about Gaza is political or analytical, going into the gory details of Israel's crimes or detailing how they relate to international law, the Genocide Convention, or recent decisions by the International Court of Justice. These are all extremely important, but this book is a diary of activities and reflections by the writer and is in some ways reminiscent of *The Diary of Anne Frank*.

Imagine a street that you travel on every day, with buildings and stores on the left and right, and neighbors that greet you as you pass by. Now I imagine walking down that same street, but all the buildings and stores are gone, and there are no neighbors left to greet you.

Plestia left Gaza at the end of 2023 and accepted the Shireen Abu Akleh Memorial Scholarship for a Master's in media studies at the American University of Beirut. In 2024 she was named One Young World's Journalist of the Year and one of BBC's 100 Women.

About the journal

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Join us. Beyond Capitalism meets over Zoom for political discussion on Fridays and film screenings on Thursdays, 7:00–9:00pm.